HW #3 Stuxnet

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**Abstract**

Stuxnet is an extremely sophisticated malicious malware that marked a pivotal point in history by being the first instance of nation state cyber-warfare. Quiet, targeted, and destructive; this malware is capable of exploiting four zero day vulnerabilities, self deletion to prevent detection, utilizing multiple stolen digital certificates. Stuxnet's purpose was to target Iranian nuclear enrichment centrifuge computer systems, specifically one's made by Siemens. What was unintended, was how far it spread outside of that intended target, affecting many other countries including India and Indonesia. Fortunately, deleting itself after June of 2012, it only added on to the drastically increasing trend of cyber-attack across the globe.

**Introduction**

With the whole world increasingly gravitating towards the reliance on digital infrastructures and systems to run everyday critical activities. We've already seen individual and criminal actors attack these systems with varying scales and damage, it comes with no surprise that we would see governments start to target and adopt these methods in their own ways for warfare purposes. 2009/2010 was this pivotal instance where a nation state used such capabilities to target Iranian nuclear centrifuges to not only steal data, but to also cause severe damage.

**Summary of the case**

Stuxnet was an extremely sophisticated malware discovered in 2010 that targeted SCADA and PLC systems, supervisory control and data acquisition systems and programmable logic controllers respectively. Stuxnet was a unique circumstance where the malware's primary goal was not to steal data, but to destroy physical infrastructure. The landscape was changing fast, with the prominence of the internet, we saw a drastic rise in cyber crime from individuals, criminals, hacktivists, and now governments.

1. **What does the threat do?**

Stuxnet was a malicious malware that was intended to target the Iranian nuclear program. It acted similarly to a worm, introduced most likely by a removable drive and propagating itself within targeted systems. As it affected systems, it would gather and process information to understand the affected system. It targeted control systems made by Siemens that were used to run Iranian centrifuges, forcing them to operate at speeds that would damage and destroy itself over time. While this occurred, the software would feed false information to mislead operators into seeing normal functions.

2. **How did Stuxnet change the game?**

Stuxnet changed the game by shifting the environment of hackers as individual or criminal attacks to sophisticated nation-state cyber-warfare. It was a world first in the capabilities of cyber activity to target other nations as a part of warfare tactics. It targeted physical infrastructure and caused severe damage. It was also recognized for how well it was able to hide itself and how specific the target was intended for.

3. **Why haven't we seen another Stuxnet? Will we?**

The resources required to develop and the logistics to implement something to this scale are far too intensive for any civilian or criminal organization to perform. Continuous escalation of this tactic will inevitably allow for other actors to retaliate with cyber-attacks of their own or even engage in traditional warfare tactics.

I believe that we inevitably will see similar events to Stuxnet in the future. The biggest deterrent is the heightened awareness to such attacks by the international community. Most governments that are capable of such have implemented defense strategies and systems to detect, prevent, and mitigate damage from attacks. One of the main reasons that Stuxnet was so prevalent was its accidental discovery. It was unintentionally spread to systems outside of the intended target and was able to propagate without oversight. One of the main functions of Stuxnet was to remain undetected by obfuscation practices and self destruction. One could argue that the process of a malware to self-delete has been one of the most important decisions to help prevent other institutions from accessing and reverse-engineering code to their own benefit. One thing that is to consider is that there could already be another instance of Stuxnet in action, but just hasn’t been detected yet.

4. **How can cyberterrorism, as represented by the Stuxnet, be successfully prevented?**

The prevention of cyberterrorism requires international cooperation to inform others of new threats. Treaties and laws should be established to set the standard. Constantly updating systems to the newest and most secure updates. Education and awareness, whether it be by funding programs or educational programs. Zero-trust policies should be the new set standard to safeguard from internal user errors or espionage.

**Conclusion**

With the resources and intelligence it took to create such devastation, there will be significant challenges to combat this threat. Steps that can help mitigate future instances include segregating networks, to prevent worm-like behaviors from allowing malicious code from spreading across whole networks. Access controls need to be more hygienic, to help users from unsuspectingly using contaminated USBs and other media. Patching needs to be done regularly, Stuxnet was able to access the internet to update itself; security systems need to mimic this adaptability to prevent perpetual blind spots. And finally, global norms need to be set in place to protect victim countries and punish aggressors.

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  Page 22-23. Disruptive and Destructive Cyber Attacks Targeting

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